PARSHAS VAYEIRA

Even the World to Come

Parshas Vayeira: Avraham, the Akeidah, and the radical mesiras nefesh of Izhbitz

With sources from the Izhbitz-Radzin school and Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin

Mei HaShiloach · Beis Yaakov
Pri Tzaddik · Tzidkas HaTzaddik

Parshas Vayeira 5787

וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ

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The Most a Person Can Give

They were tearing Rabbi Akiva's flesh with iron combs, and it was time for Shema.

So he said it.

His students could not bear to watch. *Rebbe,* they cried, *even now? Even here?* And from inside the pain, Rabbi Akiva gave them the answer Jews have carried for two thousand years:[1]

> כָּל יָמַי הָיִיתִי מִצְטַעֵר עַל פָּסוּק זֶה "בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ" אֲפִילּוּ נוֹטֵל אֶת נִשְׁמָתְךָ. אָמַרְתִּי: מָתַי יָבֹא לְיָדִי וַאֲקַיְּימֶנּוּ, וְעַכְשָׁיו שֶׁבָּא לְיָדִי, לֹא אֲקַיְּימֶנּוּ?
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> **— Berachos 61b**

"All my life I was troubled by this verse, *with all your soul*, even if He takes your soul. I would ask: When will it come to my hand, so that I can fulfill it? And now that it has come, shall I not?" He drew out the last word, *Echad*, and his soul went out with it.

That is the picture that rises in us when we hear the words *mesiras nefesh*. We carry it into Yom Kippur. The light of Ne'ilah is almost gone, the gates are closing, and a whole shul cries out *Shema Yisrael*, then seven times *Hashem Hu HaElokim*, the cry that went up on Har HaCarmel when fire fell from heaven for Eliyahu.[2]

We carry it into Unesaneh Tokef. The Or Zarua traces that prayer to Rabbi Amnon of Mainz.[3] Pressed by the bishop to convert, he asked for three days to consider, and he never forgave himself for those three days. The bishop had his hands and feet cut off, joint by joint. On Rosh Hashanah he was carried into shul, and as the chazzan reached Kedushah he stopped him: *"Wait a little, and I will sanctify the Great Name."* For me, nothing in the Yamim Noraim is more powerful than that moment. It is what a Jew is.

Every one of these pictures ends the same way: a Jew gives up his life. We assume that is the ceiling. What could be more precious than life?

The Chassidus of Izhbitz and Radzin, the world of the Izhbitzer Rebbe, his son the Beis Yaakov, and his disciple Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin, asks a question that sounds almost dangerous. What if life is not the most a person can give? What if a Jew could give up not only this world, but his place in the next?

The answer is hidden in this week's parashah. To find it, we have to begin in a furnace.

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1 Berachos 61b, on Devarim 6:5.

2 Melachim I 18:39.

3 Or Zarua II, Hilchos Rosh Hashanah 276.

The Man Who Did the Math

Avraham smashed his father's idols, and his father handed him over to the king. The Midrash records what followed like a duel.[4] *Bow to the fire,* said Nimrod. *Why not to water,* said Avraham, *which puts fire out?* Then bow to the water. *Why not to the clouds, which carry the water?* Then the clouds. *Why not to the wind, which scatters the clouds?* Nimrod had heard enough. *I bow to fire, and into it you go. Let your God come and save you.*

Standing there, of two minds, was Avraham's brother Haran, and Haran was doing the math. *If Avraham wins, I'm with Avraham. If Nimrod wins, I'm with Nimrod.* Avraham went down into the flames and walked out alive. So Haran announced which side he was on. They threw him in, and he died before his father's eyes.

Remember Haran. He is the man who serves on condition, who signs on with whoever is winning. Everything that follows is the story of his opposite.

Rav Tzadok sees two summits in Avraham's life. In the furnace, Avraham fulfilled *"with all your soul."* On Moriah he would be asked for *"with all your might," uvechol me'odecha*, and that, says Rav Tzadok, reaches something a person holds dearer than his own life.[5]

> וְכֵן קַיִּם מִקּוֹדֶם בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ בְּנִסָּיוֹן הַכִּבְשָׁן, וְאַחַר כָּךְ נִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵדָה נִקְרָא וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ, שֶׁמּוֹרֶה אַף דָּבָר שֶׁחָבִיב עָלָיו מְאֹד יוֹתֵר מִנַּפְשׁוֹ.
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> **— Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah**

Dearer than life? It sounds impossible, until the Gemara tells us there are people whose money is dearer to them than their bodies.[6] And it finds one in a tzaddik. On the night before he faced Esav, *vayivaser Yaakov levado*, Yaakov was left alone. He had gone back across the river, in the dark, for a few small jugs, and there he wrestled until dawn with the angel of Esav.[7] A man who never took what was not his could not walk away from what was.

If a jug can be worth that, what is a child worth? Our children are the part of us that goes on after we are gone. Ask any parent: they matter more to us than we matter to ourselves.

For Avraham, the thing dearer than life had a name. Yitzchak.

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4 Bereishis Rabbah 38:13.

5 Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah, maamar 15, on Devarim 6:5.

6 Berachos 61b; Mishnah Berachos 9:5; Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201.

7 Chullin 91a, on Bereishis 32:25.

His World to Come

Listen to the way the command closes in. The Midrash Tanchuma hears it as a conversation:[8]

Take your son. Which son? *Your only one.* Each is the only one of his mother. *The one you love.* I love them both. *The one you love most.* Is there a limit inside a father's heart? *Yitzchak.*

Every phrase shuts a door. By the end, there is only one name left in the room.

The Beis Yaakov tells us what that name held. Yitzchak was the promise, the covenant, the line through which every Jew who would ever say *Shema* would come into the world. He was, in the Beis Yaakov's words, *"the very essence of his World to Come."* And Avraham was ready to give even that:[9]

> וּכְמוֹ שֶׁעָשָׂה בְּהַעֲקֵידָה שֶׁרָצָה לְהַקְרִיב בְּנוֹ יְחִידוֹ אֲשֶׁר אָהַב עוֹלָה כָּלִיל לַהַשֵּׁם, וְאַף שֶׁזֹּאת הִיא עִיקַּר עוֹלָם הַבָּא שֶׁלּוֹ, עִם כָּל זֶה רָצָה גַּם בְּזוֹ הַטּוֹבָה לַעֲבוֹד בִּפְעוּלַת הַשֵּׁם וְאַף שֶׁלֹּא יִשָּׁאֵר לוֹ כְּלוּם.
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> **— Beis Yaakov, Vayeira**

"Nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service, even if nothing would remain for himself." An act like that, the Beis Yaakov says, rose all the way to *Atika Kadisha*, the most hidden height there is: *la'asar d'la isyeda*, "to the place that is not known."

Try to feel it from the inside. You have stood for one thing your entire life. You were raised on it. You built everything on it. You know, the way you know your own name, that it is why you were born. And then you are told to turn it all a full 180 degrees. This is not *I will give my life because the cause is worth it, and I will be rewarded in Olam Haba.* It is placing on the altar the one thing you have, knowing that nothing may be waiting on the other side.

Dust and Ashes

Can a person really give away his share in the World to Come? Rav Tzadok answers that Avraham already had, years before Moriah, in Nimrod's fire.

A descendant of Noach is not commanded to die for Kiddush Hashem. He is commanded not to take his own life, and in the Rambam's view, one who gives his life where the law does not demand it is answerable for his own blood. When Avraham walked into that furnace, he was not keeping a law. He was breaking one:[10]

8 Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22.

9 Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55, citing Midrash Tanchuma, Lech Lecha 3.

> וְרַק מִפְּנֵי שֶׁבָּעֲרָה בּוֹ אַהֲבַת הַשֵּׁם מָסַר נַפְשׁוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ גַּם כֵּן, וְאַף שֶׁיַּפְסִיד חַס וְשָׁלוֹם חֶלְקוֹ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא מַה בְּכָךְ, כֵּיוָן שֶׁרְצוֹנוֹ שֶׁיִּתְקַדֵּשׁ שֵׁם שָׁמַיִם עַל יָדוֹ וְיִתְפָּרְסֵם אֱלֹהוּתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שְׁמוֹ.
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> **— Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim**

"Only because the love of Hashem was burning inside him did he give over his life and his soul. And even if, Heaven forbid, he should lose his portion in the World to Come, what of it? His desire was that the Name of Heaven be sanctified through him."

What of it. Two words, and he was ready to let eternity go.

The Bnei Yissaschar goes further still. Avraham, he writes, truly believed he would be punished in the World to Come for what he was doing, and he threw himself into the flames anyway, for love.[11]

Rav Tzadok adds the war we looked at last week. Avraham went after four empires with Eliezer alone, or with 318 men, which hardly changes the odds. Nothing obligated him. By the letter of the law, he may not even have been permitted. A zeal for Hashem was burning in him, and so he went.[12]

Now listen to this week's parashah. Pleading for the people of Sedom, Avraham says, *ve'anochi afar va'efer*, "I am dust and ashes." The Midrash hears a whole life in those words: "Had Amrafel killed me, I would have been dust. Had Nimrod burned me, I would have been ashes."[13] Twice already he had stood where his life, and perhaps his eternity, was forfeit. And Rav Tzadok says that because Avraham made himself that small, mere dust and ashes in his own eyes, he reached that hidden height, *Atika*. The One who is "high and exalted" dwells "with the crushed and the lowly of spirit."[14]

Even on That Condition

Now we climb the mountain.

Samael met Avraham on the road, the Midrash says. *Old man, old man, have you lost your mind? A son given to you at a hundred, and you are going to slaughter him?* Avraham answered with three words: *al menas ken*, "even on that condition." *And if He tests you with*

10 Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7, citing Sanhedrin 74a, Bereishis 9:5, Rambam, Hilchos Yesodei HaTorah 5:4, Nedarim 32a, and Yeshayahu 57:15.

11 Agra DeKalla, Beshalach 7, on Bereishis 9:5.

12 Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7.

13 Bereishis Rabbah 49:11, on Bereishis 18:27.

14 Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7.

more than this? "Even more than this." *Tomorrow He will say to you: You are a murderer. You are guilty of your son's blood.* "Even on that condition."[15]

When Avraham would not move, the Satan turned to Yitzchak, and heard the same three words. In the Tanchuma's telling, he made one last attempt: he became a river across their path.[16] Avraham walked straight in. The water rose to his knees. It rose to his neck. *The waters have come up to my soul,* he cried. *If I drown, or Yitzchak drowns, who will fulfill Your word?* Hashem rebuked the spring, and the river ran dry.

Rav Tzadok hears something startling in those three words:[17]

> וַאֲפִילּוּ יִהְיֶה אֶמֶת שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ אַחַר כָּךְ עַל זֶה. הוּא רוֹצֶה רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְלֹא לְקַבָּלַת שָׂכָר. וַאֲפִילּוּ יֵעָנֵשׁ עַל זֶה הוּא מִתְכַּוֵּין לַעֲשׂוֹת נַחַת רוּחַ לְפָנָיו.
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> **— Pri Tzaddik, Kedushas Shabbos**

"Even if it is true that he will be punished for this afterward, he wants only to do everything for the sake of Heaven, and not to receive reward. Even if he is punished, his intention is to bring Him *nachas ruach*." Had he refused, Rav Tzadok adds, he would have been acting out of love for his son.

As I read it, Avraham never disputes the Satan's facts. *Maybe you are right. Maybe I will be punished. I am not doing this to be rewarded, and I will not refuse just to escape punishment. I want only to give Hashem nachas ruach.*

When I taught this, the room pushed back, and rightly. Hashem commanded it, so how could it be an aveirah? A proven navi may tell us to set aside a mitzvah for the hour, as Eliyahu did on Har HaCarmel, and we listen.[18] When Hashem says *do this*, it is a mitzvah. On the level of halachah, all of that is true. But there is a second layer, the one that reaches into our own lives: the ego, what I want against what Hashem wants. On that, the whole room agreed. Avraham wanted nothing for himself, even if it would cost him.

And notice what Avraham does not do. Adam had one command. Then Chava ate and did not die, and suddenly he had proof. He reasoned. He debated. He was pushed. Avraham never debates the Satan. He just says, *even so*. How often are we pulled into an argument on the other side's terms, and lose before we begin? Avraham did not overthink. He stayed on script: if this is what Hashem wants, I will do it.

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15 Bereishis Rabbah 56:4.

16 Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22.

17 Pri Tzaddik, Sefer Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, paragraph 9, citing Nazir 23b.

18 Yevamos 90b; Rambam, Hilchos Yesodei HaTorah 9:3.

That is Haran, turned inside out. Haran's question was, *Who is going to win?* Avraham never once asked what would happen to him.

No Prize

This is where the Torah parts ways with a kind of martyrdom the world has come to know too well. There are cultures that teach a person to die for a cause because a reward has been promised: paradise, glory, a place among the honored. That death is a transaction. Give your life; collect your prize.

The Torah of Avraham turns that inside out. Antigonus of Socho taught it in the first chapter of *Avos*: "Do not be like servants who serve their master in order to receive a reward."[19] It is a dangerous teaching, and some of his students' students broke from the Torah over it. Could a laborer work all day, they asked, and not be paid in the evening?[20]

So why does the Torah speak of reward at all? The Rambam answers with a child.[21] A boy will not learn for learning's sake, so the teacher offers him nuts. Later it is shoes, then coins, then honor. Every prize is beneath what it buys, but it carries the child forward until he can see the thing itself. Every parent knows the carrot, and every parent knows the day a child does something kind and needs nothing back.

The Sifrei names the prizes we chase: "Lest you say, I will learn Torah to become rich, to be called Rabbi, to receive reward in the World to Come." Read that list again. Olam Haba sits right beside money and honor. And the Sifrei answers: "Whatever you do, do it only out of love."[22]

The Beis Yaakov carries this to the edge. There is a greater avodah, he writes, in which a person gives himself over in this world and in the next, for the honor of Heaven:[23]

> כִּי יֵשׁ גַּם עֲבוֹדָה גְּדוֹלָה מִזּוֹ שֶׁהָאָדָם מוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ בְּמְסִירוּת נֶפֶשׁ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּשְׁבִיל כְּבוֹד שָׁמַיִם, כִּי גַּם כַּוָּנָה לִשְׂכַּר עוֹלָם הַבָּא הוּא גַּם כֵּן לְגַרְמֵיהּ.
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> **— Beis Yaakov, Toldos**

"For even an intention directed toward the reward of the World to Come is also for oneself." A person can walk away from every pleasure in this world and still clutch the spiritual payoff he expects at the end. So each of us has to ask, honestly: Am I serving for the prize?

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19 Pirkei Avos 1:3.

20 Avos DeRabbi Nosson 5.

21 Rambam, Introduction to Perek Chelek (Commentary on the Mishnah, Sanhedrin 10).

22 Sifrei, Devarim 41, on Devarim 11:13.

23 Beis Yaakov on Torah, Toldos, ois 24.

The Kedushas Levi finds the answer in a young woman's quiet choice.[24] Yaakov had given Rochel secret signs, knowing Lavan would try to switch the sisters. On the wedding night Rochel thought of Leah under the chuppah, about to be exposed, and she handed her sister the signs. As far as Rochel knew, she was giving up Yaakov forever, and with him, she feared, she would fall to Esav and lose her World to Come. She gave them anyway, "both her portion in this world and her portion in the World to Come, so that the Creator's will would be done."

No one saw. No one knew. That is serving without a prize.

When Love Argues Back

If not for a reward, then what moved Avraham? Love, surely. Yet Rav Tzadok makes a surprising claim: love, left to itself, would have told him to refuse.[25]

Hashem had promised, "Through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours." Avraham's life's work, making Hashem's Name known in the world, ran through that boy. Without him it would pass to Eliezer, and Avraham did not want that. So the very love that had carried him into the furnace could have argued: *Refuse. Save the boy, for the sake of Hashem's Name, and lose your World to Come for it, just as you were ready to before.*

And Avraham did not trust it. He was afraid, Rav Tzadok writes, *"suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter."*[26] Maybe his love for Hashem's honor was really love for his son. Maybe his love for his son was, in part, love for himself. So he bound Yitzchak out of awe, and that awe is what brought his love to completion. In that moment, Rav Tzadok says, Avraham, the man of chesed, "was encompassed within the fire, the attribute of Yitzchak." And he sums up Avraham's whole stance in a single line:[27]

> וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁאָמַר: מַה לִּי אִם אֵינִי מֵבִין, כֵּיוָן שֶׁכָּךְ צִוִּיתִי אֲנִי מְחוּיָב לִשְׁמוֹעַ.
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> **— Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim**

"What does it matter to me that I do not understand? Since this is what I was commanded, I am obligated to listen."

The ego is very clever. It rarely announces, *I want this for me*. It says, *this is for the sake of Heaven*. Avraham's mesiras nefesh reached even the place where he would not trust his own holy reasons when they happened to line up with what he wanted.

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24 Kedushas Levi, Bereishis, Vayeitzei 26; Megillah 13b.

25 Pri Tzaddik, Pesach, maamar 52, paragraph 1, and Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7, on Bereishis 15:2 and 21:12.

26 Pri Tzaddik, Toldos, maamar 1, paragraph 4.

27 Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7.

The Leap

If Hashem knew Avraham would pass, what was the test for? The Ramban answers that a test is for the one being tested. It draws out what lives in a person only as potential, so that he earns the reward of a good deed, and not only of a good heart.[28]

Rav Dessler, as the *Sha'arei Aharon* records from him, takes it further.[29] *Nissah*, "He tested," comes from *nes*, a banner lifted high. A test lifts a person up. Rav Dessler pictured free choice as a front line between two armies. Behind each line, nothing is chosen; there we run on habit and nature. Choice lives only at the front, and the front moves. Win, and yesterday's struggle becomes second nature, and the battle moves up to ground that was once beyond your reach.

Before the command came, giving up Yitzchak was nowhere near Avraham's front line. It was unthinkable. Rav Tzadok says that at the Akeidah Avraham gave himself over "beyond his own grasp."[30] Picture a man being chased who must leap from one rooftop to the next. He would never have dreamed of trying. But there is no choice, and the moment pulls out of him a strength that did not exist before. Rabbi Akiva Tatz puts it this way: when Hashem says *leap*, and you leap, He carries you across.[31]

Avraham went all the way to the knife. Above him, Rashi says, the angels wept, and their tears fell into Yitzchak's eyes.[32] Then came the call, *Avraham, Avraham*, and words that only a leap could have earned:[33]

> וַיֹּאמֶר אַל־תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל־הַנַּעַר וְאַל־תַּעַשׂ לוֹ מְאוּמָה כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי־יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ אֶת־בִּנְךָ אֶת־יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי.
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> **— Bereishis 22:12**

Faith Without Understanding

There was a second struggle on that mountain, and it was a struggle of the mind. Hashem had promised, "So shall your offspring be," and "I will establish My covenant with Yitzchak." Now He said, "Bring him up as an offering." Both could not be true.

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28 Ramban on Bereishis 22:1.

29 Sha'arei Aharon, Vayeira, on Bereishis 22:1 (p. 977), recording Rav Eliyahu Eliezer Dessler; Michtav MeEliyahu, vol. I, Kuntres HaBechirah, chs. 2–4.

30 Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7.

31 Rabbi Akiva Tatz, "Ordeals" (shiur).

32 Rashi on Bereishis 27:1, from Bereishis Rabbah 65:10.

33 Bereishis 22:12.

Once the angel had stopped him, Rashi says, Avraham spoke. *Let me lay out my conversation before You. Yesterday You said, "Through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours." Then You said, "Take your son." Now You say, "Do not stretch out your hand"?* And Hashem answered:[34]

> לֹא אָחַלֵּל בְּרִיתִי וּמוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אָשַׁנֶּה; כְּשֶׁאָמַרְתִּי לְךָ "קַח", מוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אָשַׁנֶּה – לֹא אָמַרְתִּי לְךָ שְׁחָטֵהוּ אֶלָּא הַעֲלֵהוּ, אַסַּקְתִּיהּ, אַחְתֵּיהּ.
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> **— Rashi, Bereishis 22:12**

"I will not profane My covenant. I never told you, *slaughter him*. I told you, *bring him up*. You have brought him up. Now bring him down."

The contradiction was never in Hashem's word, only in Avraham's understanding of it. And he climbed the mountain without having it resolved. That, says the Izhbitzer, was the real test:[35]

> עִם כָּל זֶה הֶאֱמִין בַּדְּבָרִים הָרִאשׁוֹנִים כְּמוֹ מִקֹּדֶם וְלֹא נָפְלוּ אֶצְלוֹ, וְזֹאת הָאֱמוּנָה אֵין בְּשֵׂכֶל הָאָדָם לְהַשִּׂיג.
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> **— Mei HaShiloach, Vayeira**

"He believed the earlier promises just as before, and they did not fall away for him. This faith is beyond the grasp of human understanding." Avraham did not resolve the tension. He carried both halves of it, all the way to the top.

Nefesh Is Will

So what, in the end, is mesiras nefesh? The Sfas Emes answers in a single word. *Nefesh*, he says, means *ratzon*, will:[36]

> לִהְיוֹת כָּל רְצוֹנוֹ תָּמִיד רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא וְאֵין לוֹ דָּבָר אַחֵר בָּעוֹלָם, זֶה מִקְרֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ כִּי נֶפֶשׁ הוּא רָצוֹן.
>
> **— Sfas Emes**

To give up your nefesh is to give up your own will, until nothing is left in your world but His. That is what happened on Moriah. The ego, and all the rationalizing the ego does so well, stopped standing in the way.

What mesiras nefesh produces, the Sfas Emes says, is *zerizus*: a will with nothing in its path. You can see it in the verse. *Vayashkem Avraham baboker*, he rose early. He had servants, the

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34 Rashi on Bereishis 22:12, from Bereishis Rabbah 56:8, citing Tehillim 89:35.

35 Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Vayeira, *VehaElokim nissah*, on Bereishis 15:5, 17:21 and 22:2.

36 Sfas Emes, Balak 5656.

Midrash points out, and still he saddled the donkey with his own hands.[37] He did not give the arguments time to arrive.

That is the Avraham inside every one of us. The alarm goes off for the first minyan, and the arguments begin. Get up before they finish. Do the mitzvah before the excuses start. A love like that, the Sfas Emes says, depends on nothing, and so it never ends.

Your Letter

I said this is a dangerous avodah. Here is its guardrail, and it is one of the most beautiful ideas in all of Izhbitz.

The Mei HaShiloach notices that the second paragraph of Shema leaves out "with all your might." Giving yourself over even with respect to the World to Come, he explains, belongs only to the stage *before* a person finds his own portion. Every soul has *"a particular mitzvah, through which that soul will attain the World to Come,"* and once a person has found his, *"Hashem does not wish to take from a person what he has acquired."*[38]

> כִּי לְכָל נֶפֶשׁ שַׁיָּךְ מִצְוָה מְיוּחֶדֶת שֶׁעַל יָדָהּ יַגִּיעַ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא ... אַךְ אַחַר שֶׁיִּבּוֹרַר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ לֹא יַחְפּוֹץ הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ מִן הָאָדָם שֶׁיַּעֲבוֹד אוֹתוֹ בְּזֶה הָאוֹפֶן, כִּי לֹא יִרְצֶה הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לִיקַּח מִן הָאָדָם מַה שֶּׁסִּיגֵּל.
>
> **— Mei HaShiloach, Vaeschanan**

The surrender is the doorway. Let go of your own will, and on the other side you discover what Hashem wants from *you*: the thing only you can do.

The Kabbalists read the name *Yisrael* as an acronym: *yesh shishim ribo osiyos laTorah*, there are six hundred thousand letters in the Torah, one for each root soul of Israel. Every Jew is a letter. A Sefer Torah missing a single letter is not kosher. Rav Tzadok says that every person was created to repair something in which his soul is unique, *"without an equal in another."*[39]

This is why Izhbitz has always drawn people who think outside the box. It does not ask you to become a copy of anyone else. It asks you to empty yourself of ego so completely that your own letter can finally be read.

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37 Bereishis 22:3; Pesachim 4a; Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22; Pirkei Avos 5:16.

38 Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Vaeschanan, on Devarim 6:5 and 11:13.

39 Tzidkas HaTzaddik 49. On the 600,000 letters, see Megaleh Amukos and the Arizal's writings.

Receiving It Back

None of us is being asked to climb Moriah. But the Beis Yaakov says that a mitzvah done with no ulterior motive, only for Hashem's will, "reaches higher and higher, so that it has a hold in Akeidas Yitzchak."[40]

A small Akeidah can look like this. A mitzvah no one will ever see. Tzedakah without the plaque. Honesty that costs you money. A tefillah answered *no*, and accepted with a whole heart. Your best effort, given fully, and the result released, because the success and the failure both come from Hashem. It is mesiras nefesh without a fire and without a knife.

Rabbi Akiva spent his life asking, *When will it come to my hand?* For most of us it comes in small pieces: an early morning, a kept secret, a *no* accepted with grace. Each one is a step up the mountain.

Anyone who has done kiruv, as I have, knows the answer we give when a student asks what life is for: Olam Haba. The Ramchal agrees that the World to Come is where we will delight in Hashem. Yet *Mesillas Yesharim* opens with a different question: *mah chovaso b'olamo*, what is a person's obligation in his world?[41] It is Avraham's word on the mountain: *ani mechuyav lishmo'a*, "I am obligated to listen."

A few weeks ago, on Sukkos, we held the aravah, the willow with no taste and no fragrance. The Mei HaShiloach connects it to one who gives his life for Torah and seems to gain nothing for it, not in this world and not in the next. Yet the willow must be in the bundle, because a whole Jew needs that strength too. And then he makes a promise:[42]

> וְהִיא שֶׁלֶּעָתִיד יַחֲזוֹר הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לְכָל מִי שֶׁהִפְסִיד בִּמְסִירוּת נַפְשׁוֹ עַל דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה.
>
> **— Mei HaShiloach, Emor**

"In the future, Hashem will restore to everyone what he lost by giving himself over."

The Akeidah does not end on the altar. Yitzchak walks down the mountain alive. The same surrender that carried Avraham up now asks him to receive his son back, as a gift. No longer his. Hashem's, placed in his hands.

That is the whole of it. We give it all: our comforts, our plans, our need to be seen, our hopes for our own spiritual greatness, even our need to understand. And then we receive our lives back from His hand, as a trust, and serve Him with them.

Ki nefesh hu ratzon. May we taste even a drop of Avraham's love this Shabbos. Good Shabbos.

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40 Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55.

41 Mesillas Yesharim, chapter 1.

42 Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Emor, *Chag haSukkos*, citing Bava Kamma 61a.